



German tanks and infantry, belonging to Erwin Rommel's Afrika Korps, advance across Libya during the hard-fought campaign in North Africa.

THE ENTRY OF FASCIST ITALY INTO WORLD WAR II IN JUNE 1940

extended the war into the Mediterranean and North Africa, where Italy had colonies, including Libya. Early in 1941, British Commonwealth forces, advancing from Egypt, captured the Libyan port of Tobruk and took 130,000 Italian prisoners. In response, Hitler sent General (later Field Marshal) Erwin Rommel (1891–1944) to North Africa

with an armored force—the Afrika Korps—to rescue his fascist ally. Rommel soon pushed the British back and placed Tobruk under siege, while German aircraft based in Sicily attacked British shipping and bombed the island of Malta, a vital British naval base.

The Italian army also attempted an **invasion of Greece** in 1940, but once again the Germans had to step in. Axis forces invaded **Yugoslavia** in April, which was

as **Einsatzgruppen**, were detailed to follow the armies and kill communists and Jews in occupied territory. Nazi administrators anticipated the extermination of 30 million Soviet citizens to free up food supplies for Germany.

Launched on June 22, Operation Barbarossa was warfare on a vast scale. Hitler had assembled more than **4 million troops**, including a million from his Axis allies. At first the invasion was an overwhelming success. In a series of encirclements, around 3 million Soviet soldiers were taken prisoner. The invaders reached the gates of Leningrad and thrust toward Moscow, but the **Axis advance** slowed with the autumn rains and eventually **ground to a halt in the snow**. The Soviets launched furious, often suicidal, counterattacks to drive the enemy back from the outskirts of Moscow. For the first time

“ DON'T FIGHT A BATTLE IF YOU DON'T GAIN ANYTHING BY WINNING. ”

Erwin Rommel, German Field Marshal and commander of the Afrika Korps, in his war diaries *Infanterie Greift An*, 1937



German parachute badge
German paratroopers, like airborne forces all over the world, were considered to be an elite, a status reflected in their stylish badge.

rapidly defeated and dismembered, creating an **independent Croatia** under the rule of the fascist **Ustaše movement**.

German troops pressed south into Greece, which was swiftly overrun. British Commonwealth forces attempted to defend the **Greek island of Crete**, but it fell to the Germans after an initial assault by paratroopers.

For Hitler, the Mediterranean was merely a sideshow. He had already set in motion preparations for an **invasion of the Soviet Union**, codenamed **Operation Barbarossa**. Nazi intentions were genocidal. Hitler told his generals to plan “a war of annihilation,” Special SS death squads, known

Airborne operation
The Germans used paratroopers to great success in their invasion of Greece at Corinth, and in the subsequent attack on Crete.



Operation Barbarossa

The Axis invasion of the Soviet Union made great progress in the second half of 1941. It inflicted heavy losses on Soviet forces, but failed to achieve the quick victory that Hitler needed.

KEY

- German/Axis advances
- Front line June 21, 1941
- Front line Sept 1, 1941
- Front line Nov 15, 1941
- Front line Dec 5, 1941

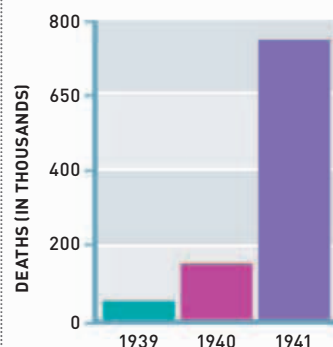
Germany had failed to achieve a lightning victory.

In the Baltic republics (Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania), Belarus, and Ukraine, much of the population **initially welcomed the Germans** as liberators from Stalinist rule. However, few maintained their enthusiasm once they experienced the brutality of Nazi rule. In Leningrad, placed under siege by German and Finnish forces, thousands died every day, mostly from starvation. Almost all the **prisoners of war**

captured by the Axis were **executed or perished** from starvation and neglect.

The Jews suffered the worst. At **Babi Yar**, outside the Ukrainian capital Kiev, more than 30,000 Jewish people were murdered in two days. The Nazis also began systematic killing of Jews in Poland, using gas vans at an extermination center at Chelmo.

Throughout 1941, Britain fought on against the Nazis, ignoring a bizarre **peace initiative by Hitler's Deputy Führer Rudolf**



Axis war casualties

The casualties suffered by Germany and its Axis allies rose dramatically between 1939 and 1941, as the war widened its grip on Europe.